and articulate leader who had backed the Aragalaya movement, won 42.3 per cent of the vote in the first round of counting. His two main rivals, Sajith Premadasa of the Samagi Jana Balawegaya (SJB) and the incumbent President Ranil Wickremesinghe of the United National Party (UNP), finished second and third, with 32.8 per cent and 17.2 per cent vote share, respectively.

Since none of the contestants had won the requisite 50 per cent-plus votes, for the first time in the country's history, the second preference votes had to be counted. That count favoured Dissanayake, but the fact that his votes came mainly from the Sinhala-dominated southern Sri Lanka and not from the North or the East where the Tamil Hindus and Muslims live was an indication that he would have to work hard to unify the country. The three-decade-long bloody civil war ended only after V. Prabhakaran, the chief of the Liberation Tigers of Tamil Eelam (LTTE), was killed by the Sri Lankan army in 2009. However, successive Sri Lankan governments have made little effort to heal the wounds of the minorities in the country.

Dissanayake truly wears a crown of thorns as Sri Lanka has yet to recover from the economic collapse it suffered in 2022 and is now confronted with a massive debt burden of over $37 billion. Dissanayake's first task would be to work out a financial plan to service the country's debt even as he has to negotiate with the International Monetary Fund (IMF) for the next tranche of its $2.9 billion bailout. The IMF had directed the government to impose heavy income taxes and take other austerity measures to make up the revenue shortfall the country was facing. While campaigning, Dissanayake had promised to get the IMF to lessen the stringency of its conditions. But the IMF is going to be a tough nut to crack and the country cannot do without its support. In his brief ad-



INDIA'S GREETINGS India's High Commissioner to Sri Lanka Santosh Jha meets Anura Dissanayake on Sept. 23, soon after he was sworn in as president

ANI

THE RISE AND RISE OF ANURA KUMARA DISSANAYAKE

- Born on Nov. 24, 1968 in Galewala, in Central Province
- At University of Kelaniya (1992-95), joins Socialist Youth Organisation (SYO), student wing of Janatha Vimukthi Peramuna (JVP), a Marxist outfit that fought to overthrow the government (1971, 1987-89)
- JVP enters mainstream politics in the '90s
- Dissanayake appointed SYO national organiser in 1997
- Is made JVP central committee member in 1998; enters parliament as nominated member in 2000
- Wins in the 2004 polls from Kurunegala; serves as minister in coalition government with Sri Lanka Freedom Party
- Replaces Somawansa Amarasinghe as JVP chief in 2014; helps steer JVP to the mainstream, stressing on fighting corruption and social justice
- Wins from Colombo in 2015 polls; serves as chief opposition whip
- In 2019, is presidential candidate of the new National People's Power (NPP) coalition of JVP and other Left leaning parties and intellectuals. He polled only 3 per cent of the votes and lost
- JVP supports the Aragalaya protests that oust the Rajapaksa regime during the economic collapse of 2022
- Fights 2024 polls as NPP candidate; elected president with 42.31 per cent votes, performs strongly in the Sinhala south; appoints NPP leader Harini Amarasuriya as PM